An Owl In The Desert

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/38301844.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra)

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by TheSofterGentlerMe

Summary

Adora is trying to understand who she is now and what that means in relation to her faith.

Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the work for more notes

“Hear my prayer, Lord; let my cry for help come to you. Do not hide your face from me when I am in distress. Turn your ear to me; when I call, answer me quickly,” Adora wrote in the notebook that Glimmer had given her. She sat and looked at the opening words of Psalm 102 she’d copied from her Bible sitting on top of her concordance beside her on the tiny table in the trailer that she and Catra shared at Camp Bright Moon. It’d only been a few weeks since she’d left Camp Horde for the Lord and the letter she’d sent to her mother had come back to her in the mail that afternoon, marked as Return to Sender.

She’d cried a little before putting the letter away and pulling her Bible out. She’d always sought refuge there in hard times and even now she did so but she couldn’t seem to find anything that helped. Everything seemed to whisper at her that she had failed a test, that she had thrown her life away for physical pleasure that was against God’s word but she still remembered the first desperate kiss with Catra on the docks at Camp Bright Moon and that feeling that everything was going to be OK. She remembered shortly afterwards shouting out the words from First John that there was no fear in love and she still felt that but doubt had oozed in.

She sat quietly, listening for the still, small voice of God that she’d always heard would come if you listened for it, but nothing came. Instead she could hear her mother’s words, spoken in the camp office the day after she’d come to Camp Bright Moon, echoing in her head.

“No child of mine will be a dyke!” her mother had shouted and Adora’s eyes filled with tears as she remembered how hateful it had sounded. Her mother had always been strict and the few

times she'd mentioned things about her mother to the people she was becoming friends with now, they'd all seemed horrified but to her, it was just her mother. However, that moment had been different. She'd never seen her mother that angry and the word her mother had used to describe what Adora was had stung deeper than she had thought possible.

Even now though, with the rejection of her mother in full display from the returned letter, Adora still thought about trying to patch it up with her. She thought about what apology might work or what else she might have to do to make her mother accept the situation or at least even speak to her. She had even thought about telling her mother that it wasn't true, she had just been confused. She looked at Catra's few clothes sitting with her own in the laundry basket waiting to be done and started to cry again as she thought about trying to ignore her and knowing she couldn't.

"Please give me guidance, grant me strength," Adora said as she grasped her hands in front of herself and prayed. She stared at the table as her hands trembled a little from how hard she held them. "What Catra means to me can't be a lie; it can't be a deceit of the Devil. I have sacrificed so much for her and I'm so scared I have failed somehow. Please, if it is Your will, show me the way."

As she prayed she kept thinking of all the times she'd hugged Catra at their old camp, all while denying what she felt. She thought of the little moments when she'd thought of Catra's face or her hands or making idle plans of how they could be roommates in the future, all while denying her feelings. Then she remembered Catra telling Adora that she loved her and how Adora had tried to shut it out at first.

She shook her head as she tried to pray again but instead she remembered holding Catra as floodwaters raged and then after, standing on a dock as everything crashed in on her of what had happened before she finally pulled Catra close for that first desperate kiss and how good it had felt to finally admit what she felt. Then she thought of waking up before her now and watching her sleep in the early morning light twinkling through the glass crystals in their window, and she couldn't focus.

"Am I just damned?" Adora whispered. She looked up at the ceiling as she spoke louder. "Is that it? Is Catra right? You created me, made me this way, and then cursed me for it?"

Again, there was no answer. Adora's head dropped as she spoke again.

"I've lost almost everything. My mother, my home, my future, and all I want is some kind of sign that I've made the right choice. When I'm with Catra, I feel that it's right but doubt is still there. Is this a test like Job or is this punishment?" Adora said and a defiant part of her spoke up. "If I'm going to burn in Hell for eternity, why would you begrudge me a few years of happiness before then?"

Then she deflated, the defiance leaving her as quickly as it'd arrived, and Adora waited, hoping she'd feel moved but nothing came. She picked up the pen she'd been writing with and tried to write but nothing came to her. She had her head in her hands when Catra walked in.

“Adora! I have had the greatest day… what’s going on?” Catra said.

Adora looked up, not sure why she felt guilty, as she saw Catra looking at the Bible, the concordance, and the notebook.

“I was doing some studying,” Adora said as she closed the notebook.

Catra came and sat down at the little table, as the close confines of the trailer filled with the smell of horses and hay coming off of Catra from her day in the barn. She looked down at the open Bible and then back up at Adora.

“You haven’t done this since we left,” Catra said. “What’s different?”

Adora felt like she’d been caught as she said, “I, uh, didn’t ever stop. I just didn’t do it when you were around.”

Catra looked at her before sighing as she said, “Why?”

“I just didn’t,” Adora said as she reached to pick up the Bible.

“Adora, I’m not an idiot. You’re not the same here,” Catra said quietly as she took the Bible before Adora could get it. “These last few weeks, you’ve been pretty quiet, and then I find out you’re hiding this from me…”

Adora looked down at the cover of the closed notebook as Catra trailed off. The notebook was covered in glitter and had colorful geometric shapes in various shades of purple and pink on it. She ran her finger down one shape as she said, “I’m just confused. I’m seeking guidance.”

“From this?” Catra said, holding the still open Bible up. “You’re trying to get guidance on what exactly?”

Adora didn’t want to say anything and Catra stared hard at her before she said, “You’re reading in the Old Testament. What guidance are you trying to get there? On us? On what we are? I’m pretty sure I know what you’re going to read.”

Adora looked up at Catra, as she shook her head as she said, “It’s not like that.”

Catra had a hand on the edge of the table and she felt her hand clench tight on it as she fought back the urge to cry. She fought down the sorrow as she sat the Bible back on the table and spat out, “Yeah, it is. If you’re going to leave me because you’ve got some screwed up guilt, then just tell me. Don’t try and find some God damned magic words to try and make yourself feel good about it.”

Adora froze at Catra's words and all she could do was barely shake her head.

"You can't even say something for yourself, can you?" Catra said as she stood up, tears finally pooling in her eyes. Adora found herself trying to think of how to explain what she was going through but couldn't manage as Catra let out a disgusted sigh of anger that was betrayed by the tears tracking down her face. She turned and left the trailer, the exterior door creaking open as she left before the spring on it slammed it shut like a pronouncement of doom.

Adora stared at the door, not believing what had just happened, before she got to her feet and went out the door. It was only a moment but by the time she got outside, she didn't see Catra. There were several directions she could have gone, down a trail into the trees and brush right next to the trailer, up around the house where Glimmer's parents lived, or even behind the trailer and then away. She tried to think which way she would have gone when Glimmer came walking into the backyard.

"What's up, Adora?" Glimmer said with a smile and then noticed the panicked look on Adora's face. "What's going on?"

"I had an argument with Catra and she's taken off," Adora said, the words spilling out like water from a busted bottle.

Glimmer came over, her hands up in front of her as she said, "Whoa, slow down, I got about half that. Did you say Catra ran off?"

Adora nodded as she started to sniffle.

"Why!?" Glimmer said as she helped Adora sit down on the little metal step outside the door.

"She thinks…," Adora started to say before she started crying and buried her face in her hands. She took huge deep breaths, doing her best to stop the crying. She knew how much it annoyed people when she did as her mother had pointed that out to her time and time again.

"Adora, it's alright," Glimmer said and then was shocked to see Adora look back up her eyes red but the tears gone.

"It's not," Adora said, her voice quavering as she fought to keep her tears down. "She thinks I want to leave her."

"You? You two are disgustingly cute together. What makes her think that?" Glimmer said.

"She came into the trailer and I was praying and studying and I think I freaked her out," Adora said.

“I don’t get it,” Glimmer said as she leaned against the trailer by Adora. “Why would that freak her out?”

“I don’t know!” Adora said, her voice started to raise in her worry. “I just, I’m confused and I wanted some guidance and so I went to the Word like I always do but it’s just not working and now I think I’ve driven her away and I’m scared and…”

Glimmer knelt down and put a hand on Adora’s shoulder as she said, “Hey, whoa, slow down. I don’t know what happened but I’m sure it can be worked out. Do you want me to find her?”

“What? You know where she is?” Adora said.

“Nope, but I can find her. Want me to?” Glimmer asked again.

“Yes,” Adora said, nodding quickly.

Glimmer unclipped the radio from her belt and held it up to her mouth.

“Glimmer to everyone. Anyone seen Catra running around? Sound off if you’ve seen her please. Over.”

Adora waited, her hands clenched, when she heard Bow's voice come over the radio.

"Hey, Glimmer, I saw her go past us here at the archery field a few minutes ago. She was headed towards the campfire ring I think, over," Bow said.

"Thanks, babe," Glimmer said with a smile. "Glimmer out."

Adora was getting to her feet as she said, "Thank you so much."

"Do you want me to…," Glimmer started to say when she realized she was talking to Adora's back as she went running. Glimmer sighed and shook her head. "And I thought Bow and I getting together had some drama."

The campfire ring for the camp wasn't too far from where the trailer was located. Adora took a shortcut that she knew and got there pretty quickly. The site was surrounded by tall cottonwood trees and the ground was soft soil with plenty of sand in it. Catra sat on one of the benches that surrounded a campfire pit in a semicircle, her head hung low. With the light filtering through the fluttering leaves of the cottonwood, Adora was reminded of a church with a tall ceiling and she looked around the space and felt like it was a special spot. She stood there in the quiet, not sure what to say.

“Hey, Adora,” Catra said, her voice sounding defeated. She didn’t look up but Adora started to slowly walk towards her.

“Can we talk?” Adora said and Catra looked up, bitter laughter mixing with her tears as she replied.

“Oh, of course, yes, we can,” Catra said. “Let’s just go ahead and get this over with. What verse am I going to be treated to of why you still care about me but just can’t stay with me?”

Adora sat down on a bench close to Catra as she said, “I’m sorry, I should have been more specific when you came in. I was scared for some reason and I froze and…”

“Stop,” Catra said, holding her hand up. “I can see this coming. I was too happy so of course something had to happen to smash it down. I don’t get to be happy.”

“Do you want to leave?” Adora said and she didn’t bother to hide the tears this time.

“No!” Catra said, turning to her.

“Well I don’t want to either!” Adora said, throwing her hands up in the air before sagging a bit. “I just… I’m scared. You know I sent a letter to Mom…”

“Yeah, and what? She wrote back telling you how to earn your way back into her good graces?” Catra said, her voice sharp.

“It came back as Return to Sender,” Adora said quietly. “She never even opened it.”

Catra looked away for a moment before she scooted a little closer to Adora as she said, “You don’t need her approval. She’s a bitch.”

Adora flinched as she said, “Come on. I know you don’t like her but she’s my mom.”

“And she’s cruel to you,” Catra said.

Adora started to say something but just shut her mouth as she saw what Catra was saying. The two sat for a moment before Adora finally spoke up.

“I’m not leaving you and I’m not looking for a reason to leave you,” Adora said.

“Then why are you hiding that you’re reading the Bible? Why are you even bothering? I mean, I know you took it with you but I

thought it was just being fast in packing or something," Catra said. "I figured you'd be done with that crap."

Adora shook her head as she said, "I'm not. I still pray. I still read and study the Word. It can't all be…"

"Trash? Superstition?" Catra said. Adora gave a little silent laugh as she heard Catra's voice change to one of gentle teasing.

"No, not that," Adora said. "I believe God made me which means God made this in me. Like I said the night we left, there's no fear in love and when I'm with you, I'm not afraid. I'm not scared of loving you."

"Then what are you seeking guidance on?" Catra said. "That's what you said back at the trailer."

"I… I don't know," Adora said. "What to do, I guess."

"That's not very comforting," Catra said, her voice flat.

"I'm just scared that I've ruined your life with this," Adora said, as she fought to find the words she needed. "I'm just scared that this will be a disaster."

Catra slid a little closer to her as she said, “Adora, these last few weeks have been the best that I could remember since, well, maybe ever. Whatever happens, happens and I’ll face that with you but you really haven’t been you lately. You’re really quiet and withdrawn so what do you think I’m going to think when I come in and you get all quiet and defensive?”

“You could have waited,” Adora said. “You could have talked to me.”

“I tried! You got all silent on me!” Catra said.

Adora said, “I’m sorry! I just couldn’t find the words to say what I needed to say and then you said that you thought I was trying to leave you and it shocked me! I don’t know! When I’m with you, it feels right, it feels good but I still have these whisperings that what I’m doing is wrong. I’m trying to find something to tell me that I’m right. That what I feel is the right thing.”

Catra leaned back and looked up at the canopy of trees overhead as she said, “The first morning we were here, I woke up and looked at you sleeping. At first I was happy because hey, the thing I used to dream of was happening but then I just knew that this, what’s going on right now, was going to be a thing. You always believed way more than I did. I believed as much as I needed to get by but you believed deeply. Sometimes I even envied that in you but now,” Catra said as she looked down at Adora, “I’m scared but I’m going to say this clearly. If you go back to all of that, I’m not going to be your dirty little secret. I hid myself for long enough and I’ll be damned if I’m going to do that again.”

“You don’t want me to read the Bible or study it?” Adora said.

“That’s not it,” Catra said. “I get that it’s important to you but you need to find space for who you are and who I am in that dogma.”

Adora sighed a little in relief and Catra raised an eyebrow in question.

“That’s what I was kind of trying to do,” Adora said. “Maybe that’s not exactly how I had it phrased but that’s what I was looking for. I’m sorry I hid it from you.”

“It’s alright,” Catra said as she scooted a little closer and Adora held out a hand. Catra took it. They were still far enough apart that she could barely hold on but she still held tight. “Just don’t preach at me and I guess I’m sorry for making you think you had to hide that.”

Adora squeezed Catra’s hand as she scooted a little closer to her.

“It’s alright. I’m just… I guess I’m going to be quiet a lot. I mean, everything I ever thought I wanted has changed. I thought I’d go to school, find someone to have kids with, settle down, go to church, and just you know, grow old. I’ve got to think about that.”

“What do you want now, Adora?” Catra said quietly as she scooted close enough for their hips to touch. Adora turned and

looked at her and leaned forward to answer her question. After they kissed she leaned back.

"That for now," Adora said with a little smile on her face.

Catra smiled back as she said, "OK, so we've made up I guess but seriously, you don't have to change any of that. You can still go to school. It's early but if we stick together, I'm not completely opposed to having kids with you."

"You'd grow old with me?" Adora whispered and Catra looked into her eyes and melted.

"If you let me," Catra whispered back. The two leaned against each other and looked at the fire pit for a little bit before Catra finally stood up and pulled Adora to her feet. "Come on. It's going to be dinner soon. I want to shower the barn off and tell you about my day."

Adora hugged her close as she said, "You said you had a great day when you came in. I'm sorry I ruined it."

"You didn't ruin it," Catra said. "Come on."

The two walked back to the trailer hand in hand. As they passed the archery field, Adora saw Bow putting up the equipment with another counselor. Bow waved and Adora waved back and then

she noticed him pick up his radio and start talking and she blushed hard as she realized they were both probably the talk of all the counselors at the camp. She didn't stop to find out though because Catra was telling her about the farrier who'd come to camp to put the horseshoes on the horses and how she'd got to help out.

"It was really cool," Catra said. "Even let me hammer out a horseshoe and help put it on the horse."

"Explains why you smell like horse so much," Adora said as they got back to the trailer.

"Oh, I'm sorry. I didn't see you complaining when I was kissing you earlier," Catra said with a laugh.

"I was distracted," Adora said. "Go on in and get cleaned up."

"You're really going to sit out here. We live together, Adora," Catra said.

Adora blushed as she started to stammer something out and Catra shook her head.

"Nope. I humored you on that long enough. You sleep beside me. We can be in the same trailer while the other takes a shower," Catra said. "Come on."

Catra took her hand and led her into the trailer. Adora sat at the little table with her back towards the bedroom while she heard Catra start laughing at her.

"Seriously!?" Catra said.

"I wasn't kidding when I said I wanted us to go slowly when we first moved in," Adora said, blushing so hard she felt like she had a sunburn. Catra's shirt flew past Adora and landed on the tiny little kitchenette setup that Adora was facing. Then she felt Catra kiss the top of her head.

"You did and I agree," Catra said. "I'm still going to tease you a little about it because I love you, goof ball."

Adora felt her heart speed up a little as she said, "I love you too."

Catra went into the shower whistling and the little trailer was soon muggy from the steam. Adora looked down at the Bible that was still open in front of her and moved it to her. She wasn't really reading, she was just thinking, wondering what a sign would look like when Catra came out of the shower again.

"You know, I'm thinking about getting an undercut," Catra said. "My foster mom used to say they made people look like a lesbian

but I always liked them. Since I'm openly a big ol' dyke now I guess I should have a haircut that shows that off."

Adora laughed as she started to say something about how she thought that might look good on her when she suddenly thought about the word that Catra used. It was the same word her mother had thrown at her but when it came out of Catra's mouth, it had sounded like an affirmation, a claim of selfhood. Then she looked at the verse her hand was resting on.

"All day long my enemies taunt me; those who rail against me use my name as a curse," Adora quietly read.

"What'd you say?" Catra said as she stepped into the little room wrapped in a towel to grab her shirt.

"Nothing," Adora said as she looked away from Catra with a smile. "I was just reading. You absolutely should do the haircut. It'd be great."

"Don't tempt me. I know Bow has some hair clippers. I could do it tonight," Catra said with a laugh as she went back to the bedroom.

Adora looked at the verse again. Maybe it was a sign. Maybe it wasn't. All she knew for certain was that she loved Catra and Catra loved her back and while the future was uncertain, it always was going to be that way no matter what. She reminded herself of

the thing she'd told Catra standing in the mud and darkness beside the river the night they'd left. She'd said she wouldn't lie about who she was anymore and she was beginning to understand that if she spent her life understanding herself, as long as she kept being honest about who she was, it would be a life well spent.

End Notes

When I originally wrote *Camp Horde for the Lord*, I didn't give a lot of thought to what would happen after Adora and Catra left. However, as I wrote it and I knew that Adora was going to go to school to get a Religious Studies degree I knew she wasn't going to just up and leave her faith. Then I realized that she was going to have moments of doubt and that this was going to cause some conflict with Catra because as she said, she only had faith to make it through what she was going through. Adora had it much more deeply. I kind of went back and forth on this fic and I hope I got across what I was trying to convey, a person suffering a crisis of faith.

I'd be remiss if I didn't call out the song I wrote most of this to on repeat: Psalm 102 by Semler. I saw someone recommend it on Tumblr a few weeks back, about when I was really getting into the writing for *Camp Horde for the Lord* and I've been obsessed with it. That droning style of music is like catnip for me. See also Pnuema by Tool for another example. Anyway, thank you for reading and I hope you enjoyed this!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!